



BS Degree Programme - IIT Madras

Strategies for Professional Growth

GP2 Report on

***Building Effective Team Dynamics through
Conflict Management and Negotiation Skills***

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Methodology

Objective

To investigate how conflict management and negotiation skills support the development of strong team dynamics, based on real-world professional experiences and validated frameworks. The study aimed to analyse the underlying causes of workplace conflict, effective resolution strategies, the role of leadership and emotional intelligence, and the impact of negotiation on long-term collaboration and cohesion.

Team Formation & Leadership

Team 12 comprised five members, with responsibilities distributed based on individual strengths and professional networks. Each member independently sourced and conducted an interview with a working professional, then contributed to collective analysis and documentation.

Primary Data Collection – Interviews & Discussions

Five semi-structured interviews were carried out with professionals from varied industries and different levels of experience. A common interview script was developed covering: causes of conflict, resolution strategies, negotiation techniques, emotional intelligence, and career impact.

Interviewee	Designation	Industry	Experience	Interviewed By
Mansi Devrukhkar	Full Stack Developer, Studio Frontier	IT	5 years	Shravani
Shubham Singh	Senior Associate Consultant, Infosys	IT	5+ years	Vedant
Sasidharan Pillai	Director of Operations, Publicis Groupe	Media	20 years	Samarth
Ms. Vidhiya Kumar	Senior Business Analyst, UPS Technologies	IT	10+ years	Deebhika
Pranshu Gupta	Interior Designer	Design	3 years	Saksham

Secondary Data Collection

The team supplemented primary insights with research drawn from established frameworks and publications, including:

- Goleman's Emotional Intelligence model (self-awareness, empathy, regulation, social skills)
- Fisher & Ury's Getting to Yes: principled negotiation and win-win frameworks.
- Harvard Business Review articles on conflict resolution and leadership.
- Crucial Conversations by Kerry Patterson – focuses on managing high-stakes discussions effectively in professional and interpersonal settings.

Ethical Considerations

All participants provided informed consent. Identities of participants who preferred confidentiality are anonymised. Data collected was used exclusively for academic purposes with integrity and accuracy maintained throughout.

Analysis of Findings & Recommendations

Overview of Findings

Conflict Is Inevitable

The findings suggest that conflict in the workplace is a frequent and inevitable element of team interactions. The most common causes of conflict include:

- Ineffective communication and ambiguous requirements
- Lack of clarity in roles and misaligned expectations
- Variations in experience and expertise levels
- Competing priorities (such as speed versus quality or client demands versus feasibility)
- External constraints like strict deadlines and evolving requirements

These conflicts are largely task-related in nature, but they can become more challenging when they escalate into personal or interpersonal disagreements.

"Conflict is not the problem, how we handle it determines whether it becomes productive or harmful."
- Sasidharan Pillai, Director of Operations, Publicis Groupe

2. Emotional Intelligence as the Driving Force Behind Conflict Management

A recurring insight from all interviews was that emotional intelligence particularly self-regulation, empathy, and active listening play a vital role in managing conflicts. Vidhiya Kumar demonstrated that combining empathy with accountability leads to improvement, while Pranshu Gupta stressed that empathetic engagement is more effective than purely logical approaches during challenging discussions. Staying composed and understanding others' perspectives is more beneficial than purely rational arguments in complex situations.

3. Negotiation as a Daily Professional Practice

Negotiation was not viewed as a formal or occasional process but as an integral part of everyday professional interactions. Vidhiya Kumar described a common approach of simplifying complex client demands into practical alternatives, such as replacing a pop-up with a toggle feature. Shubham Singh highlighted resolving a frontend-versus-backend disagreement by testing both solutions and selecting the more efficient one based on results. Similarly, in Pranshu's residential design project, a prolonged disagreement over colour choices was resolved through a structured review using 3D visualisations and guidance from a neutral senior, leading to a mutually acceptable hybrid solution.

"Sometimes, it's not about proving yourself right, but about working effectively as a team." - Mansi Devrukhkar, Studio Frontier

4. Leadership, Ethics, and Structural Clarity

Leadership was consistently characterized as facilitative rather than authoritative. Vidhiya Kumar emphasized that ethical leadership involves making decisions that serve the project's best interests. According to Samarth's interview, effective leaders bring teams together by focusing on common goals. Shubham Singh noted that discussing issues with senior team members and maintaining collaboration are essential in conflict resolution. Clear role allocation and organized feedback systems further reduce conflict frequency

5. Early-Career Blind Spots

Interviews consistently indicated that junior employees often face challenges in handling feedback, including ego-based responses, misinterpretation of guidance, and reluctance to challenge ideas. Vidhiya Kumar recommended expressing disagreement through structured arguments backed by facts. Shubham Singh highlighted that viewing feedback negatively can limit career advancement.

"If you are a new person and want to learn and grow, don't take feedback on your ego." - Shubham Singh, Infosys

Recommendations

Based on the convergence of primary insights and secondary literature, the following recommendations are proposed for individuals, teams, and organisations:

For Individuals

- Take a moment to pause and reflect before reacting, especially in high tense or pressure situations. Building self-awareness helps you respond more thoughtfully rather than just emotionally.
- Try to separate personal ego from professional feedback, not every critique is a judgment, often it's just useful input that can help you improve.
- When having disagreements, focus on understanding the underlying interests instead of getting stuck on fixed scenarios. This makes it easier to find solutions that work for everyone.
- Use structured communication techniques, facts, prior agreements, shared objectives when challenging authority.

For Teams

- Start projects with clear roles and shared expectations so everyone knows what they're responsible for. This reduces confusion and prevents avoidable conflicts later on.
- Create a friendly environment where people feel safe to speak up and share honest feedback without worrying about being judged or ignored.
- Whenever possible, address issues within the team before escalating them to higher authorities. Working through challenges together often strengthens trust and collaboration within the team.
- For more complex disagreements, use structured approaches like review meetings, visual aids, or even a neutral third person/party to keep discussions balanced and productive.

For Organisations / Leaders

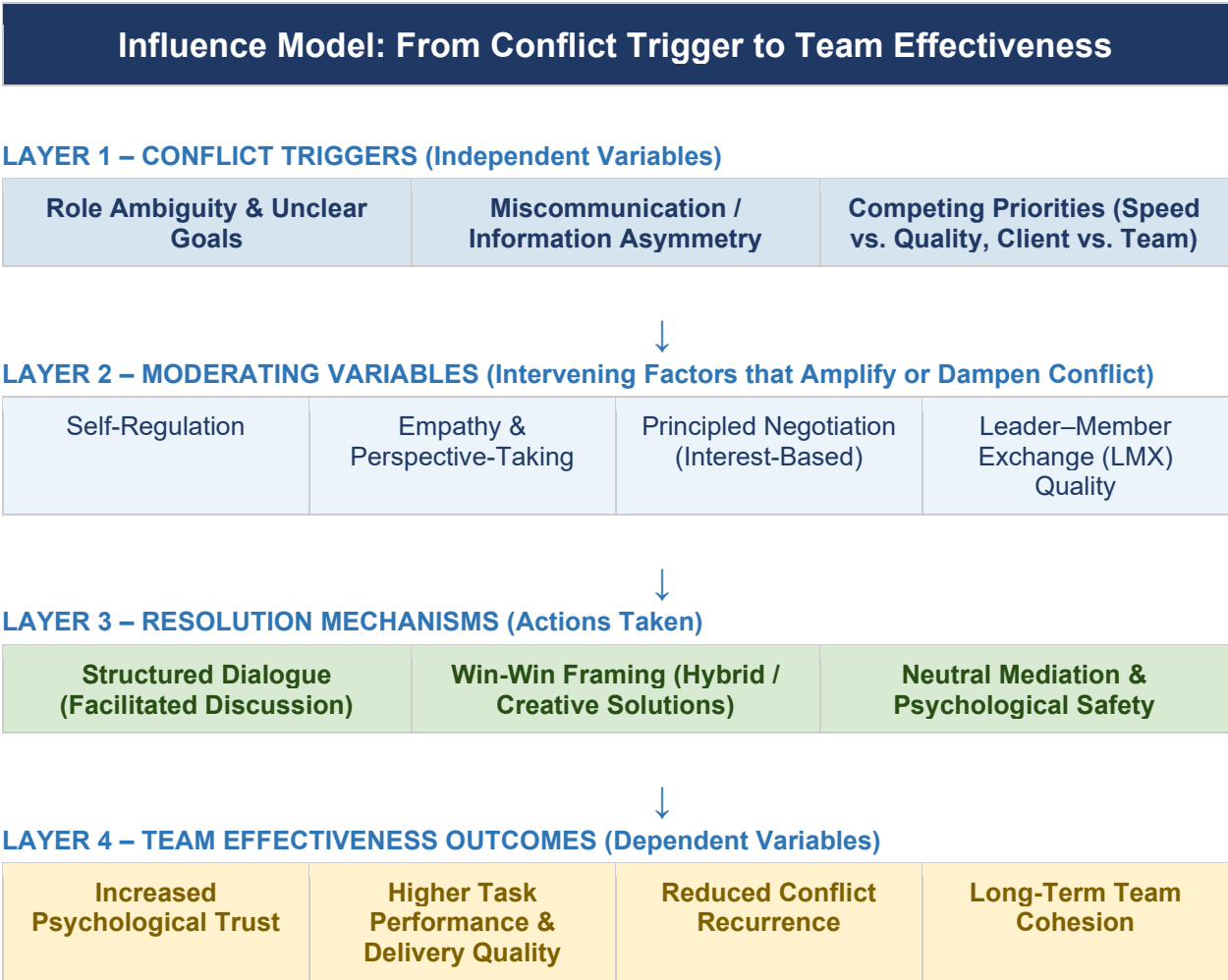
- Leaders should set the tone by demonstrating emotional intelligence in their actions, showing empathy, taking accountability, and making fair and unbiased decisions for the team.
- It's worth investing in training programmes that build skills in conflict management and negotiation, especially for new employees and emerging leaders.
- Having clear and structured processes for resolving conflicts, such as defined escalation paths or mediation steps can prevent confusion and reduce bias.
- Finally, make sure incentives encourage collaboration rather than competition. When teams are aligned around shared organisational goals, they're more likely to work together effectively instead of operating in solely.

Overall, managing conflict well is not just about avoiding problems, but about handling them in a better way. When individuals stay aware, teams communicate openly, and leaders set the right example, it becomes much easier to deal with challenges. Over time, these small efforts build stronger relationships and a more positive work environment. It also helps people feel heard, respected, and more willing to work together. In the end, this is what allows both people and organisations to grow steadily and succeed.

SECTION C

Application / Influence Model

The diagram below presents an influence model grounded in our field investigation. It maps the key variables that determine whether team conflict leads to dysfunction or becomes a driver of improved team performance. The model is built from real patterns observed across the five interviews rather than adapted from a single external framework.



Model Interpretation

The model operates in a layered causal flow. Conflict triggers (Layer 1) are structural and situational largely unavoidable in collaborative work. Their impact is mediated by Layer 2 variables, which are primarily skill-based and learnable. Self-regulation prevents reactive escalation; principled negotiation reframes the conflict around interests; LMX quality determines whether team members feel safe raising concerns.

Layer 3 mechanisms translate individual EI capacity into collective action: structured dialogue aligns competing teams, win-win framing expands the solution space, and neutral mediation de-politicises the

resolution process. When these mechanisms are applied, Layer 4 outcomes follow not as a guarantee, but as a statistically dominant pattern observed across all five interviews.

Critically, the model also has a feedback loop: effective resolution outcomes increase LMX quality and psychological safety (Layer 2), which in turn lowers the severity of future conflict triggers. Teams that resolve conflicts well become more resilient to future conflicts a compounding dynamic.

Case Illustration – Design Conflict Resolution

In Pranshu Gupta's residential project case, the colour-palette dispute maps directly onto the model:

Model Layer	Real-World Mapping
Trigger (L1)	Client vs. lead designer disagreement on colour palette; competing creative visions
Moderating (L2)	Pranshu maintained self-regulation; senior consultant provided empathy without bias
Mechanism (L3)	Structured visual review session (3D renders) + neutral senior facilitator → hybrid solution
Outcome (L4)	Procurement resumed; timeline restored; both parties satisfied; relationship preserved

This model is not domain-specific. As demonstrated across IT, banking, corporate, and design contexts, the same causal structure holds only the surface-level vocabulary and tools change. What remains constant is the role of self-regulation and structured facilitation in converting conflict into a constructive team experience.

Project Review & Closure

Task Summary by Team Member

Roll Number	Name	Task Undertaken
23f2005291	Vedant Goyal	• Interview of Primary Resource (Shubham Singh, Senior Associate Consultant, Infosys) • Methodology • Compilation and Documentation of Final Report in GP2
23f2004763	Samarth S	• Interview of Primary Resource (Sasidharan Pillai, Director of Operations, Publicis Groupe) • Analysis and Recommendations • Team coordination and progress check-ins • Compilation and Documentation of Final Report in GP2
22f3000721	Saksham Gupta	• Interview of Primary Resource (Pranshu Gupta, Interior Designer)

		• Project Review and Closure • Compilation and Documentation of Final Report in GP2
23f1001691	Deebhika K	• Interview of Primary Resource (Ms. Vidhiya Kumar, Senior Business Analyst, UPS Technologies) • Influence Model • Compilation and Documentation of Final Report in GP2
23f1001996	Shravani Bugdani	• Interview of Primary Resource (Mansi Devrukhkar, Full Stack Developer, Studio Frontier) • Project Presentation • Compilation and Documentation of Final Report in GP2

Challenges Faced

Coordinating schedules across five team members alongside the availability of external participants proved to be the most significant logistical challenge. Aligning interview timings, collecting video snippets, and ensuring all submissions met the required format and naming conventions required consistent follow-up. Synthesising qualitative findings from five distinct industries and professional contexts into a coherent unified analysis also demanded multiple rounds of discussion and revision.

Best Practices Followed

The team maintained a shared document for collaborative editing. A common interview script was developed early on, ensuring comparability of primary data. Regular check-ins were held to align on analytical themes and resolve any interpretive differences. Tasks were distributed according to individual strengths, and all deliverables were cross-reviewed before finalisation.

Recommendations for Future Teams

Future teams should finalise interview schedules at least two weeks before the submission deadline to allow adequate time for analysis and compilation. Establishing a shared folder structure from the start

with agreed naming conventions significantly reduces last-minute confusion. Assigning a dedicated document lead for formatting and coherence can also improve the overall quality of the final report.

Team Reflection

This project has been a valuable learning experience for Team 12. Through real-world interviews and collaborative research, we gained a deeper understanding of conflict management, negotiation, and team dynamics — both as academic concepts and practical realities. Each member contributed their strengths, and the process taught us the importance of communication, collaboration, and shared ownership. We are grateful to all five professionals who generously shared their time and insights to support this project.